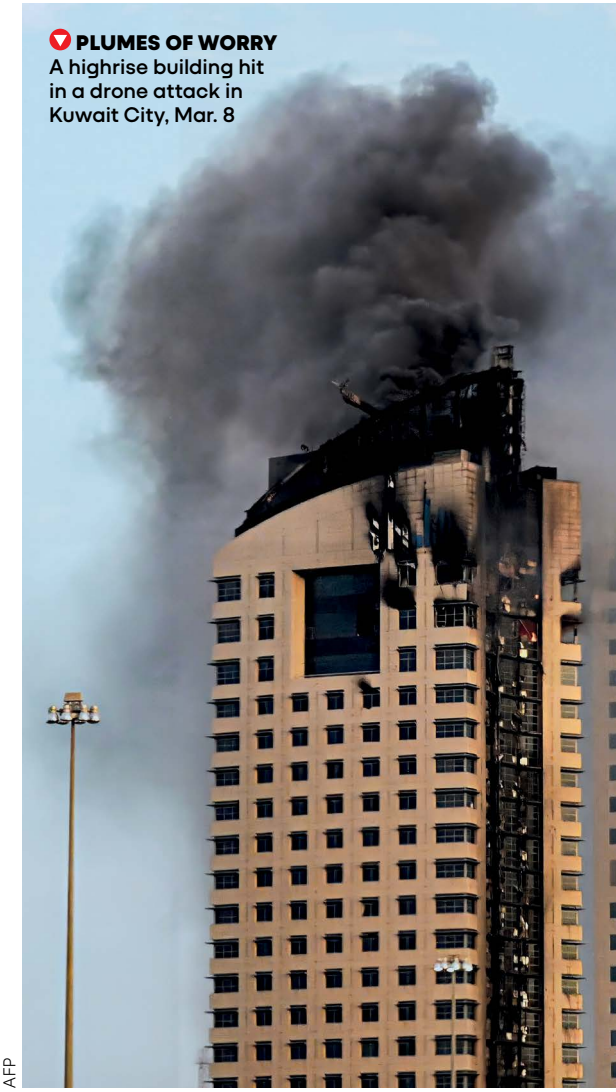
Wanted: A New Security Architecture



***Bader Mousa Al-Saif**, Professor of History at Kuwait University and Fellow at Chatham House (UK) and the Arab Gulf States Institute (US) and previously deputy chief of staff to a former PM of Kuwait, speaks to* INDIA TODAY *on how the Iran war has impacted Kuwait*



PLUMES OF WORRY A highrise building hit in a drone attack in Kuwait City, Mar. 8

AFP

Q.

How serious has the impact of the Iran conflict been on Kuwait and the Gulf so far?
It's too early to tell because the conflict has been ongoing for almost six weeks and we just arrived at a temporary (and one can claim, fragile) two-week ceasefire, so a full assessment isn't possible yet. But the impact has been visible on several fronts: political, economic, social and psychological. Most clearly, on the economic front, with disruptions caused by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz and the dismantling of usual supply chains. Then there are direct attacks on critical infrastructure: oil and gas refineries, power plants, desalination plants, government buildings like the Kuwait Petroleum Corporation and ministries, and even residential areas.

All of the damage need to be tabulated comprehensively to estimate reconstruction needs. Numbers being discussed across the Gulf run into billions of dollars when combining the impact on multiple states, though again, it is early. The good news is that we have the financial capacity and institutional resilience to recover. Kuwait has faced worse during the Iraqi occupation in 1990–91 and earlier during the Iran–Iraq war (1980–88) when tanker warfare and attacks affected us. We recovered then, and we will recover again.

Q. Has this conflict derailed Kuwait's growth plans, and how has the country responded so far—both militarily and economically?
The first priority has been defending the homeland, and in that regard, Kuwait has done a phenomenal job. The impact could have been worse, which speaks to the adeptness and resilience of the armed forces that courageously intercepted most of the 1,100-plus distinct attacks on Kuwait. Interception rates have been high, over 90 per cent, and daily life has largely continued as normal. Precautionary measures were taken early—shifting work and education online, reducing workforce presence and clearly communicating contingency plans. On growth plans, it is again too early to quantify the impact, but there will certainly be consequences. Priorities will shift, particularly toward strengthening defence and reevaluating our international investment footprint to better serve our national interests. At the same time, this moment validates earlier investments in defence partnerships.

This is a turning point for the Gulf. It forces a rethink not just of security, but also of economic priorities and regional relationships—with Iran, with fellow Gulf states, and with external partners. It also pushes us toward a more collective regional approach, while engaging both global powers and emerging middle powers like India and Turkey. The situation is marked by unpredictability—especially from the US. Even President Trump has acknowledged this unpredictability, but calls it a master strategy. To me, it appears more like a master folly.